

Filters@Hotmail



Hotmail was one of the most spammed e-mail services on the Internet, until they implemented strict anti-spam measures. The simple reason for this is dictionary-based spamming software. These software use a 'must-be' logic to send mail. Common names and names with an incremental index at popular e-mail services become a very strong target. Thus, the software assumes that addresses such as john@hotmail.com and john27@hotmail.com will definitely exist. If a message bounces back, the software simply won't send a mail to it for a few months. If you have a Hotmail address, it is very likely that you've been getting a lot of spam on it.

Hotmail's Junk Mail filter is definitely effective, but not a 100 per cent solution. Setting up the filter is as simple as enabling it from the Mail Options. Hotmail saves all e-

mail identified as spam in a folder called Junk Mail, where you can review all of it at one go and, if required, move some to another folder.

A much more effective way to keep unwanted e-mail out of your mailbox is to fill up the Contacts list. Add all the people that you want to receive e-mail from to the Contacts and set the Junk Mail Filter to Exclusive. This way, only people in your contacts will be able to send you e-mail and everything else will be blocked. An easy, though not very nice, way of adding contacts to the list is by sending an e-mail to everyone you know—on sending the e-mail, Hotmail provides the option to add the addresses to your address book.

Next, you may want to define a Safe List. E-mail from addresses and domains in this list will be able to reach your inbox. For example, if you receive various



Use the Exclusive filter at Hotmail to keep spam at bay

newsletters from ZDNetIndia.com, you can add it to the safe list. Once you have the Contacts and Safe list ready, simply switch to the exclusive filter and you're done. Remember to update your contacts list regularly.

offer spamware—software that helps spammers, such as e-mail harvesters, bulk mailers, open-relay sniffers, etc—itself will cut down spamming drastically because it is these tools that make spamming very easy.

SpamNet (www.cloudmark.com) is a relatively new service with a convincing concept—compile information from users and users' habits to identify and eradicate spam. The concept is based on the fact that users don't like spam, yet do nothing about it because spammers are only more encouraged by any action taken. Thus, SpamNet provides a plugin that works through Outlook 2000 and XP (they promise to release plugins for other mail clients soon). When you receive a mail, you can mark it as spam or an authentic message. The information is reported to SpamNet where it is analysed against similar responses from thousands of users (SpamNet already has over 50,000 users). A positive response from a user improves the quality rating of the site or source of the message, while an abuse report goes against it. Also, each user is scored according to the number of valid reports and this score factors into the score of the domain. Finally, this real-time list is used to filter out spam as it zips across the Internet, trying to get to your mailbox.

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Havoc Systems, a spam organisation, started sending over 50 million spam messages per week in mid-2001. They sell e-mail databases at \$129 (approx Rs 6,450) for 15 million addresses!

So what does all this mean?

Spam is just as ugly as politics—nobody likes it, most don't do anything about it and a few make millions from it! Large organisations (and gangs) are built around the spamming business and even some ISPs have tied up with them (they treat their own anti-spam policies as very, very fine print), making big bucks in the process. Those who haven't, lose out on not only money, but also make huge losses in terms of bandwidth wastage. Again, all anti-spam activists agree that e-mail marketing is definitely good for business. They suggest that only the opt-in kind of marketing, where users explicitly choose what they want to receive, should be allowed. Spam practices that assume that if a user does not opt out means that he agrees to receive future mailers, should be discontinued. In fact, on May 30, 2002, the European Parliament passed a law stating these rules, making them effective across the European Economic Area.

However, having seen and suffered the failure of all anti-spam practices and laws over so many years, many organisations and activists have taken radical steps. Hotmail implements probably the strictest algorithms on spam—if it smells like spam, it is

deleted irretrievably. Also, rather than using a per-message or per-site logic, Hotmail blocks out entire ISPs known to support spam. Thus, if any mail is sent from or to that ISP even on a non-abusive site, it is deleted. These policies are over and above the MAPS system that Hotmail uses. E-mail identified by MAPS as unsolicited is moved to a Junk Mail folder for the user's scrutiny.

A lot of subscribers to various e-mail services have realised that they are losing important messages irretrievably. Anti-spam organisations maintain that they simply have to be radical. Even with their strictest measures, some amount of spam still manages to sneak through. Users, on the other hand, maintain that this does not justify loss of important messages. At the same time, there are tens of thousands of users who are very happy with the new anti-spam practices. Feedback from some indicate a cut in spam between 75 to 100 per cent!

Server-based anti-spam software is still in a nascent stage. Several services such as SpamCop and SpamNet are working hard towards getting a clean list of spammers and authentic marketers, but this can only develop over time. We can help them develop faster by providing them with more accurate feedback. There is no fool-proof solution to spam, but these services seem quite capable of controlling it to a very large extent. ■

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